Lesson 04: Pronunciation: Consonants and Linking

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 1.6: Consonants; 1.7: Linking Consonants to Vowels.

In this lesson

You will look at the consonant sounds of American English and notice how they move from the front to the back of the mouth. Then you will learn to link a consonant at the end of a word to a vowel at the start of the next word. You will practice with sentences from the Berlin video and record yourself.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the difference between consonant letters and consonant sounds.
- Give an example word for each consonant sound.
- Name pairs of unvoiced and voiced consonants, such as /p/ and /b/.
- Link a final consonant to a vowel at the start of the next word.
- Hear linking in fast speech and use it when you read aloud.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
consonant	a letter that is not a vowel (not A, E, I, O, U)	b, c, d, f, g ...
phonemic chart	a chart with one symbol for each sound of English	/p/ as in "people"
unvoiced / voiced	made without your voice / with your voice	/p/ is unvoiced, /b/ is voiced
linking	joining the last consonant of a word to the first vowel of the next word	time off → ti-moff
fast "d" sound	a final /t/ before a vowel often sounds like a quick "d"	at a → a-də
covered in	there is something everywhere on it	The dog is covered in mud.
symbol of unity	a picture, thing or person that reminds us of the connection between groups of people	A flag is a symbol of unity for a country.
green escape	a beautiful natural place with lots of plants and trees, for a rest or a break	It's a nice quiet green escape from the city.
full of	with very many people or things inside	The room is full of people.
head over to	an informal way to say "go"	Head over to my house after work.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
You can't come to ... and not ...	you must do this when you visit; don't miss it	You can't go to Mexico and not eat street tacos.

Rules and explanations

Consonant letters and consonant sounds

- There are 21 consonant letters in the English alphabet: all the letters that are not vowels (A, E, I, O, U).
- A phonemic chart shows **sounds**, not letters. On the American English Phonemic Chart (by Adrian Underhill), the consonant sounds are in the bottom three rows:
  - Row 4: /p/ /b/ /t/ /d/ /tʃ/ /dʒ/ /k/ /g/
  - Row 5: /f/ /v/ /θ/ /ð/ /s/ /z/ /ʃ/ /ʒ/
  - Row 6: /m/ /n/ /ŋ/ /h/ /l/ /r/ /w/ /j/

Sounds move from front to back

Say the sounds in row 4 from left to right. /p/ and /b/ start at your lips. /t/ and /d/ use the front of your tongue. /k/ and /g/ are at the back of your mouth. The sound moves backwards.

Voiced and unvoiced pairs

The sounds come in pairs. /p/ is unvoiced (no voice, only air) and /b/ is voiced (you use your voice). Other pairs: /t/ and /d/, /k/ and /g/, /f/ and /v/, /s/ and /z/. You will learn more in Unit 2.

Linking consonants to vowels

- When a word ends in a consonant and the next word begins with a vowel, link the consonant to the vowel: the consonant seems to start the next word.
- Why? The final consonant is easier to say, your speech sounds more natural, and you will start to hear native speakers do this.
- Examples: time off → ti-moff; date of → da-tof; keep up → kee-pup; at a → a-ta.
- Listen for **sounds**, not letters. "hours" starts with a vowel sound (the h is silent), so "ten hours" links: te-nours. "one" starts with /w/ and "unity" starts with /j/ as in "yes", so these words start with a consonant sound.

Final /t/ becomes a fast "d"

When a final /t/ links to a vowel, it often sounds like a fast "d": date of = da-dəv; at a = a-də. You can also hear it in "a lot of" (a-lo-dəv) and "Forget about it" (for-ge-da-bou-dit).

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no /p/ sound, so "pick" and "bick" can sound the same to you. For /p/, close your lips and push out a small puff of air, with no voice. - Arabic has /f/ but no /v/. For /v/ (as in "vintage"), put your top teeth on your bottom lip, like /f/, and use your voice.

Practice

The audio clip for exercise 5 is in the attachments folder for 1.7 Linking Consonants to Vowels on your computer (folder "01.07-linking-consonants-to-vowels"), or on the original web page.

1. Consonant sounds. For each consonant sound in rows 4, 5 and 6, write one word that has the sound. Use words from this unit when you can. Book examples: /p/: people, place, pick. /b/: ball, bike, birthday. Then say row 4 from left to right and feel the sound move back in your mouth. Ask your tutor to check your words.

2. Watch. Watch Rachel's English, "Linking Consonants to Vowels" (link below).

3. Recording 1. Write these phrases and mark each link with _ (example: time_off). There are 11 links. Check your answer in the Answer key. Then say the phrases, record yourself, listen, note your mistakes, and record again. Score: _____ / 11

- What's up?
- ten hours a day
- That's what I thought.
- What is it?
- It's his anniversary.
- I'm on the train.
- This is too much.
- Forget about it.

4. Phrases from the book's slides. Say each phrase, then each example, with linking. Mark the link in each phrase.

- covered in: It's covered in art and graffiti. / The children are covered in paint.
- symbol of unity: The Olympic rings are a symbol of unity for all the countries that participate.
- green escape: Parks in New York and London offer a nice quiet green escape from the busy, noisy, stressful cities around them.
- full of: It's full of wild deer and other animals. / The glass is full of water.
- head over to: I'm going to head over to campus after my meeting.
- You can't come to ... and not ...: You can't go to Thailand and not eat mango with sticky rice.

Then make your own sentence with each phrase about your city, and say it to your tutor.

5. Listening quiz. Play "Linking_Listening_Practice" and write the missing words. Spell them correctly. You can do this as many times as you want.

1. The Berlin Wall is between East and West Berlin. It's covered ____ ____ and graffiti.
2. Brandenburg Gate is a symbol ____ ____ between East and West Germany, so it's ____ ____ site to visit.
3. Tiergarten is ____ ____ the biggest parks in the city. It's a nice quiet ____ ____ from the city. It's ____ ____ wild deer ____ ____ animals.

4. If you want to see some cool ____ ____, then ____ ____ to Friedrichshain. There are ____ ____ ____ old warehouses that are now cafes and art galleries.
5. You can't come to Berlin and ____ ____ ____ Currywurst!

6. Notice linking. Use the five full sentences in "Notice: Linking Practice" in your printed lesson (or exercise 5 with the missing words). Find each final consonant and draw a line to the vowel at the start of the next word.

7. Recording 2. Read the five sentences aloud with all the links. Record yourself, listen, make sure you linked every place you marked, and record again. Then read them to your tutor and ask where you stopped between words.

Speak with your tutor

- "Say a consonant sound, like /θ/ or /v/. I will give you a word with that sound. Tell me if my word is correct."
- "I will read eight short phrases, like 'What is it?' and 'Forget about it'. Tell me if I linked the words or stopped between them."
- "Ask me about a park in my city. I will answer with 'full of', 'one of' and 'head over to', and link the words."

Read aloud

1. time_off (ti-moff)
2. keep_up (kee-pup)
3. date_of (da-dəv)
4. What_is_it? (↘)
5. Forget_about_it. (↘)
6. It's full_of wild deer_and_other_animals. (↘)
7. There_are_a lot_of_old warehouses. (↘)
8. You can't come to Berlin_and not_eat_a Currywurst! (↘)

Watch online

- Rachel's English, Linking Consonants to Vowels: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7tsljuK4f2E
- 25 Things to do in Berlin (listen for linking): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lw5NHQeXzpA

Answer key

1. (example answer) Row 4: /p/ people, /b/ ball, /t/ ten, /d/ deer, /tʃ/ chick, /dʒ/ January, /k/ cat, /g/ garden. Row 5: /f/ fit, /v/ vintage, /θ/ thought, /ð/ that, /s/ sit, /z/ zoo, /ʃ/ ship, /ʒ/ usually. Row 6: /m/ man, /n/ neighborhood, /ŋ/ hang, /h/ hill, /l/ lamp, /r/ relax, /w/ wall, /j/ yes.
2. No key.
3. What's_up? / ten_hours_a day / That's what_I thought. / What_is_it? / It's his_anniversary. / I'm_on the train. / This_is too much. / Forget_about_it. With the fast "d": wha-dai, wha-di-zit, for-ge-da-bou-dit.
4. covered_in, symbol_of, green_escape, full_of, head_over, Thailand_and not_eat. (example answer) My city is full of small cafes. You can't come to my city and not visit the old market.
5. (book) 1 in art. 2 of unity; an important. 3 one of; green escape; full of; and other. 4 street art; head over; a lot of. 5 not eat a
6. 1. The Berlin Wall_is between_East_and West Berlin. It's covered_in_art_and graffiti.
   2. Brandenburg Gate_is_a symbol_of unity between_East_and West Germany, so it's_an_important site to visit.
   3. Tiergarten_is one_of the biggest parks_in the city. It's_a nice quiet green_escape from the city. It's full_of wild deer_and_other_animals.
   4. If you want to see some cool street_art, then head_over to Friedrichshain. There_are_a lot_of_old warehouses that_are now cafes_and_art galleries.
   5. You can't come to Berlin_and not_eat_a Currywurst!

"deer_and", "other_animals", "There_are" and "are_a" link because American English says the final /r/. Fast "d" sounds: Gate_is, art_and, street_art, lot_of, that_are, not_eat_a.

7. The same links as in answer 6.

My notes